

SELLER'S GUIDE

Selling Your Home, Step by Step

What to expect from the day we list to the day you hand over the keys.

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PART 1

Getting Ready to List

Fix it, clean it, or wait

Fix what's broken. Roof leaks, plumbing problems, anything structural. A buyer's inspection will find these, and you'd likely have to fix them before closing anyway.

Clean everything. A deep clean, carpet cleaning where needed, and less clutter. It costs little and makes a big difference.

Wait on updates that are a matter of taste. Paint and new carpet can wait until a buyer asks, unless something really stands out, like a bright purple room. If a buyer asks, we can handle it with a credit toward their closing costs, or a lower price.



Papers to gather

Before we list, it helps to gather a few papers. Having them ready answers buyers' questions early and keeps closing on schedule.

Must have

- **Your loan information.** The name of the bank that holds your mortgage, and a recent statement. The closing attorney uses it to pay off your loan at closing.
- **The age of your roof, heating and cooling system, and water heater.** Buyers always ask. You'll also need these for the state disclosure form, where you tell buyers about any problems you know of.
- **Neighborhood association papers, if you have an association.** The rules, the fee, and a contact name.
- **Termite papers.** Lenders usually want a termite inspection before closing. A termite contract that passes to the buyer is a plus.
- **Septic and well records, if your home has them.** Any pumping, testing, or repair records.

Good to have

- **Receipts for repairs and upgrades.** They show what was done, and when.
- **Warranties that pass to the buyer.** Roof, heating and cooling, appliances, or a home warranty plan.
- **A survey.** A drawing of your property lines.
- **Permits for additions or big changes.** For example, a finished basement or a new deck.
- **Your power, water, and gas bills while the home is for sale.** Buyers often ask what the home costs to run.
- **Every key, garage remote, and gate or alarm code.** You'll need them by closing day.

Can't find everything? Gather what you can, and I'll help with the rest.

Photos

Most buyers see your home online first. The photos decide whether they come see it in person.

I take your listing photos myself, with a professional-quality camera, lighting and a tripod. I edit every photo so your home looks its best. Every home I list also gets professional drone shots at no extra cost to you, so buyers can see the whole property from the air.

A few things that help on photo day

- A good cleaning. Photos show dust and streaks.
- Clear counters and less clutter. One or two nice items is plenty.
- Beds made and fresh towels out.
- Every light on and the blinds open.
- Cars, trash cans, and pet items out of sight.
- A mowed lawn and a swept porch.
- Valuables put away, and family photos thinned out if there are a lot.



Setting your price

How we set your price

I prepare a market analysis for your home. It compares your home to similar homes nearby: what sold, what's for sale now, and what didn't sell. You get a price range and the price I recommend. The final decision is yours.

Why starting too high usually costs you

- Buyers pay the most attention in the first few weeks.
- A high price puts your home next to nicer homes at that price.
- The buyer's bank won't lend more than its appraiser says the home is worth.
- Homes that sit get price cuts, and buyers wonder why.

I'll always tell you honestly what I think your home will sell for, even when it's not what you hoped to hear.

Buying your next home

Most of my sellers need a place to move. So we usually work on both at the same time.

How it usually works

- We list your home and start looking for your next one.
- When you find it, your offer can depend on your home selling. That way you're not stuck owning two homes.
- I schedule both closings for the same day. Your sale closes first, and that money goes toward your new home.

Why your price matters here, too

A seller is more likely to accept an offer that depends on your home selling when your home is priced to sell. That's one more reason we price it right from the start.

PART 2

While Your Home Is for Sale

Getting the word out

Here's how I make sure buyers find your home.

- **My own website.** Your home gets its own spot on jrREsales.com, with all the photos and details.
- **The MLS.** That's the listing system every local agent searches. From there, your home is sent to hundreds of home-search websites, including Zillow, Realtor.com, and Homes.com.
- **Facebook and Instagram.** I post your home on my business page.
- **Your neighbors.** I mail "just listed" cards nearby. Neighbors often know someone who'd love to live close by.
- **A yard sign.** Plus a flyer box out front, if you'd like one.
- **Great photos.** My own listing photos plus professional drone shots, used everywhere your home appears.

What about open houses?

I don't usually recommend them. Most visitors are curious neighbors. Open houses mostly help the agent meet new buyers, not sell your home. If you'd still like one, just ask.



Every listing gets professional drone shots at no extra cost to you.

How showings are set up

Agents book showings through ShowingTime, a scheduling service.

- **If you live in the home,** ShowingTime sends you a text, an email, or both with the requested time. Please approve it, or suggest a time that works better.
- **If the home is empty,** showings are usually approved automatically.

A quick reply helps. A buyer who can't get in often moves on to the next house.

The lockbox

I put an electronic lockbox on your door. It holds a key for showings.

- **Only licensed REALTORS® can open it.**
- **It keeps a record.** It logs who opened it and when, and when the key went back.
- **It flags surprises.** If someone opens it without an appointment, I'll know.

If you'd like, I can also add a simple combination lockbox. That's handy for an inspector or a repair person. It's your choice.

Even with a lockbox, it's wise to keep valuables and medicines put away.



Showings

You'll usually know about a showing ahead of time. That gives you a chance to tidy up.

Before buyers arrive

- Cool in summer, warm in winter.
- A quick clean, and no dishes in the sink.
- Most clutter put away.
- Lights on and curtains open. The brighter, the better.
- Pets in a crate, if possible. If not, a clear note saying where they are.
- Then step out for a while.

Why step out?

Buyers want to open closets and talk freely. That's hard to do with the owner in the next room.

After a showing

After each showing, ShowingTime asks the buyer's agent for feedback. Most agents answer, though usually briefly.

I'll pass along what's useful. If several buyers mention the same thing, like the price or a repair, I'll tell you. That's worth knowing.

Please don't take any one comment too hard. It's one buyer's opinion. What matters most is what we hear again and again.

PART 3

From Offer to Closing

When an offer comes in

I'll provide you with a summary of the offer. Then I'll call you to go over it. If you'd rather meet in person, we can.

Together, we decide what to do. You have three choices:

- **Accept it** as written.
- **Make a counteroffer.** That's your reply with changes, like a different price or closing date.
- **Turn it down.**

Either way, I send the paperwork to you on dotloop, the app I use for signing online. If you counter, I make the changes first. Then it goes back to the buyer's agent.

Most offers go back and forth a few times before both sides agree. That's normal.



The due diligence period

Once we agree on an offer, the buyer usually gets about two weeks to look the home over. This is called the due diligence period.

During this time

- The buyer's inspector checks the home.
- The buyer may ask for repairs.
- The buyer can back out for any reason at all. Even if they decide the dog next door barks too loudly.

If the buyer backs out

The contract sets a fee the buyer must pay to walk away. They pay it only if they back out. To back out, they must send written notice and a check for the fee before the period ends. After that deadline, the buyer can't back out for those reasons.

Repair requests and the termite inspection

After the inspection, the buyer may send a list of repairs they'd like. This has to be settled before the due diligence period ends.

You don't have to agree. For each item, you can:

- Say yes.
- Say no.
- Offer something else, like a credit toward the buyer's closing costs, or a lower price.

If we can't agree, the buyer may back out. If the buyer asks for nothing by the deadline, they take the home as it is.

The termite inspection

A licensed pest company also inspects the home, usually around the same time as the home inspection. If it finds termites or damage, you're expected to treat and repair it, or work out a credit or lower price with the buyer.

How long until closing?

Most closings take 4 to 6 weeks from the day we agree on an offer. Many are done in about 4 weeks. If everyone is ready sooner, we can often close early.

1

Weeks 1 and 2

The home inspection, the termite inspection, and the due diligence period. Any repair requests get settled.

2

Weeks 2 and 3

The buyer's bank orders the appraisal and works on the loan. The closing attorney checks that the title is clear. That means making sure nobody else has a claim on your home, like an unpaid loan or bill.

3

The last week or two

Final loan approval. You set up moving and get ready to hand over the keys.

4

Closing day

You sign the papers, and the home belongs to the buyer.

The appraisal

Most buyers get a loan. Their bank hires an appraiser to set the home's value. The bank won't lend more than that value.

If the appraisal comes in lower than the sale price, you and the buyer talk it over. You might lower the price, the buyer might pay the difference, or you might meet in the middle. Most contracts depend on the appraisal, so if you and the buyer can't agree, the buyer may back out.

This is why I price your home carefully from the start.



Moving out and the final walk-through

Please be fully moved out before closing.

The final walk-through. On closing day, the buyer walks through the empty house one last time. They're checking that it's the way they agreed to buy it and that nothing was damaged during the move.

Power and water: As a courtesy, please leave them on for a day or two after closing. That gives the buyer time to put them in their name.

Closing day

In South Carolina, an attorney handles every home closing. Usually one attorney handles the closing for both sides.

Most of the time, you and the buyer meet at the attorney's office at the same time. You sign the papers there. The attorney pays off your loan. Then you get the rest of your money by check, or by wire transfer straight to your bank account. You choose.

> **Bring every key, garage remote, and code to the closing table.** You hand them over there. After that, the home belongs to the buyer. Unless you become friends and they invite you over!



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Thinking about selling? Call or text me anytime. I'll walk you through every step.

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Principles Before Profits

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